

The Last Word

Keep It Complex

TO JUDGE BY one disturbing trend that I have noticed in this country is that many people have started to talk in terms of declining standards in education. This has been the case in much of the west for over 30 years – although my personal experience is restricted to the UK.

Part of the reason that I got into a full-time job on a computer magazine was the dramatic and deliberate drop in syllabus standards; I was working as a teacher of maths and physics at the time, and was horrified by what was forced upon us. The trend had started a few years before, and has continued since, but it was such a shock that it drove me out of teaching. This was deliberately contrived by the government of the day, and this fact certainly keeps me in touch with my inner conspiracy theorist; but let's not dwell on the causes or the reasons.

The result has been a dramatic drop in educational standards, right across the board. The information age? What use is information without understanding? IT – information technology, again, useless without understanding.

Einstein said something to the effect that technology was an axe in the hands of a psychopath; certainly it is dangerous in the hands of the ignorant. Look at Wikipedia. Such a brilliant idea, and so dangerous a tool. Much information in there is correct, but much is misleading and downright wrong. With subjects that are sensitive to some extent – climate change, GM foods, etc. – zealots have taken over and rigorously enforce their views. One scientist whose views were clearly not liked by the zealots decided that he would at least be safe correcting the mistake in his entry for his year of birth. The next day his correction was undone and the mistake replaced. Now that's dedicated zealotry!

How are we to judge this and other sources of information? Only a well educated society can properly make such judgements. We live in a world that is increasingly dependent on science and technology. The issues we face, and decisions that we collectively have to take, are also increasingly complex and technical. A dumbed-down, under-educated society is exactly the opposite of what we need as we move forward.

We should also be able to rely on the piercing analysis of a free press. But in the UK at least, the main organs of the press have similarly slid down the intellectual ladder. Not all, of course; there are still a few havens of clear, critical thought, but the main channels, such as BBC news, and so forth, are hardly worth attention, with their own patronising political agendas. Alright then, yes, I am mainly referring to the BBC.



Edward Henning, Editor-in-Chief

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Of course one answer to all this is computers. I am always reading about the great benefits computers can bring to the classroom – in the computer science lab or physics class, OK, but computers often become screens behind which bad teaching hides, and a source of infinite distraction. Education is about learning sets of ideas and facts, and about learning tasks – how to do certain things. The more a machine is capable of doing things for you – and a modern PC is extraordinarily capable – the less you will learn for yourself.

This really is yet more dumbing down rubbish. I agree here with the head of Intel of a few years back, Andy Grove, a very thoughtful and intelligent man. A man who wanted to sell as many microprocessors as possible but who said that there were two things in life that should not be computerised, and the other one was education.

Come on India, education is one area where you really should not emulate the west. There are families in the UK who send their kids to school over here, because they know they will get a better education.

Let's keep it that way.

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